

The emergence of the Charlestown Navy Yard

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The Charlestown Navy Yard has always been invisible to anyone who didn't happen to work there, hidden and gray behind the Mystic Bridge.

But now, with plans to turn the yard into a vital part of the city, the old place is emerging slowly into public consciousness, like a photographic print gradually darkening in the developing tray.

It's been almost five years since the announcement that the yard would stop building for the Navy. Since then it's been proposed for private industrial use, for the Kennedy Presidential Library and for other purposes. So far that's all been words. But the planning has been going on and now, with the site work under way for a new city

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park, visible change is coming to the yard.

Most people, including me, have trouble grasping the scale of the yard's opportunities. A few numbers may help.

There are, for instance, no fewer than 79 buildings in the yard (my own count), not including sheds. Some of them are immense. The structure known prosaically as Building 149, for instance, has almost half the total floor area of the John Hancock tower. Another, Building 58, the Rope Walk, is about as long as two Hancock towers laid end to end — a position in which, come to think of it, many Bostonians once feared to see the Hancock. The Rope Walk also happens to have been designed by one of Boston's best architects, Alexander Parris, who designed the Quincy Market complex.

The whole Navy Yard is 130 acres, as big as five Boston Commons, yet it's only a ten-minute walk from the North End across the Washington street bridge.

Besides size and location, the yard also boasts good architecture. Once you take a walk around it and get out of the habit of thinking of it as the perfect setting for one of those postwar bombed-out James Mason spy mysteries, it starts to look very handsome. There are bulky granite wharf-like structures with walls a yard thick, as fine as Lewis or Mercantile Wharf. There is the elegant, octagon-shaped, white-cupola-topped Muster House. And there are the more recent Kong-Kong scaled factories of brick and concrete and glass, which helped the yard and its South Boston annex build 165 ships of 100 feet or longer in World War II. With their own kind of spare good looks they help make the yard a 150-year museum of American industrial architecture.

The best way to imagine the future yard is to think of it as three sections gathered around a green park.

Section one is a National Historic Site around the U.S.S. Constitution. Section two is the Historic District, the old part of the yard, back from the



1973 aerial view of the Charlestown Navy Yard gives one a sense of the vastness of the area, the scale of the buildings and its potential for the city.

water, including the eight old granite buildings that give the yard much of its character, among them the Rope Walk and the Foundry. These buildings will be converted to museums (including the history of the Navy Yard), housing and other uses. The huge Building 149, which has a six-story glass-roofed central courtyard, is planned as a new home for the Mass. College of Art.

Section three is the newer part of the yard, fronting the water. It will be

recycled mostly as housing, with new townhouses and apartments and a public marina.

At the hinge of this three-part layout is the new park, larger than Waterfront Park, being designed by Childs Bertman Tseckares Associates Inc. The park will be surrounded on three sides by recycled buildings, the fourth side will be open to the old dry dock and look south toward the Constitution. Its design is a pleasant mix of rolling

lawns, tree-lined paths and an elaborate fountain.

The BRA's book of guidelines for the yard is an index of the size of the project. Each of some 40-odd buildings has been measured and drawn, the history of each researched and recorded. Guidelines give detailed instructions about what to save, what to restore in each building. Private developers will recycle the buildings following the guidelines, while the city itself paves, plants and lights the streets. One street,

Second avenue, will be restored to its turn-of-the-century appearance.

Like the downtown Waterfront, the Navy Yard has been slow getting going, but the opening of the park in spring '79 may change all that. Among planners, the hope is that the yard will not only succeed as a live, mixed use chunk of city, but will set off a chain reaction of waterfront renewal at the Chelsea naval hospital, East Cambridge, Revere Beach and other sites.